



LUMBER is transported in Scotia, Calif., which is struggling to survive the loss of timber and cannabis jobs. GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times

A company town looks to remake itself — one house sale at a time

Pacific Lumber is no more. Can the Humboldt County enclave it built find new life as a real estate gem?

By Jessica Garrison

SCOTIA, Calif. — The last time Mary Bullwinkel and her beloved little town were in the national media spotlight was not a happy period. Bullwinkel was the spokesperson for the logging giant Pacific Lumber in the late 1990s, when reporters flooded into this often forgotten corner of Humboldt County to cover the timber wars and visit a young woman who had staged a dramatic environmental protest in an old-growth redwood tree.

Julia “Butterfly” Hill — whose ethereal, barefoot portraits high in the redwood canopy became a symbol of the Redwood Summer — spent two years living in a thousand-year-old tree, named Luna, to keep it from being felled. Down on the ground, it was Bullwinkel’s duty to speak not for the trees but for the timber workers, many of them living in the Pacific Lumber town of Scotia, whose livelihoods were at

stake. It was a role that brought her death threats and negative publicity.

The timber wars have receded into the mists of history. Old-growth forests were protected. Pacific Lumber went bankrupt. Thousands of timber jobs were lost.

But Bullwinkel, now 68, is still in Scotia. And this time, she has a much less fraught mission — although one that is no less difficult: She and another longtime Pacific Lumber employee are fighting to save Scotia itself, by selling it off, house by house.

After the 2008 bankruptcy of Pacific Lumber, a New York hedge fund took possession of the town, an asset it did not relish in its portfolio. Bullwinkel and her boss, Steve Deike, came on board to attract would-be homebuyers and remake what many say is the last company town in America into a vi-

[See Scotia, A10]

Fire-scarred businesses still struggling

Some owners are rebuilding in Los Angeles area; others have given up

By CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN AND ROGER VINCENT

The charred remains of the historic Pacific Palisades Business Block cast a shadow over a once-bustling shopping district along West Sunset Boulevard.

Empty lots littered with debris and ash line the street where houses and small businesses once stood. A year since the Palisades fire roared through the neighborhood, only a handful of businesses have reopened.

The Starbucks, Bank of America, and other businesses that used to operate in the century-old Business Block are gone. All that remains of the Span-

ish Colonial Revival building are some arches surrounding what used to be a busy retail space. The burned-out, rusty remnants of a walk-in vault squat in the center of the structure.

Nearby, the Shade Store, the Free-est clothing store, Skin Local spa, a Hastens mattress store, Sweet Laurel Bakery and the Hydration Room are among the many stores still shuttered. The barbershop Gornik & Drucker doesn’t know if it can reopen.

“We have been going back and forth on what it would take to survive,” co-owner Leslie Gornik said. “If we open, we have to start over from scratch.”

Hundreds gathered around Busi-

[See Businesses, A17]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times
A YEAR after the Palisades fire, Business Block remnants stand.



BIKERS RIDE along the Snake, a famous stretch of the Mulholland Highway. ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

Thrill seekers return to Mulholland

Noise and recklessness rumble back with vengeance

By CLARA HARTER

Its serpentine curves have entranced drivers for decades, and even lured some to their death.

For motorcycle and car enthusiasts, riding the hair-raising turns of the 2.4-mile

section of Mulholland Highway known as “the Snake” can feel akin to a religious experience.

When the road reopened after a nearly seven-year closure in December, its devotees returned in droves.

“It is so gratifying, so tactical, it clears my head and

reinvigorates my soul,” said Malibu resident Doug Baron, who fell in love with the canyon road while cruising it alongside childhood friend Chad McQueen in the late 1970s.

But locals who live at the base of this motorsports

[See Mulholland, A12]

A TIMES INVESTIGATION

Auto crashes, costly surgeries and big payouts

Small L.A. law firm that grew into a powerhouse is drawing scrutiny

By REBECCA ELLIS

Sreen Banna said the partners of Downtown LA Law Group called her “Erin Brockovich” for her work helping hundreds sue over noxious fumes spewing out of a landfill in northern Los Angeles County.

An ambitious paralegal, Banna said she embraced the role she had in empowering residents to take on companies suspected of polluting their neighborhoods.

Her bosses were proud too, she said. Banna, 28, recalled them saying she would make them all billionaires someday.

But in early 2024, Banna said, she discovered a troubling trend in some of the firm’s most lucrative cases: Clients who claimed they were paid before joining lawsuits.

On Dec. 16, Banna sued

Downtown LA Law Group, also known as DTLA, stating the firm failed to address her complaints about “illegal solicitation, as well as deceptive and unethical practices aimed at persuading individuals to become clients through misrepresentations.”

She accused the firm, which she left in the fall of 2024, of amassing plaintiffs through “practices that appeared designed to exploit vulnerable individuals.”

DTLA called the allegations “baseless,” saying they came from a disgruntled former employee.

“Any allegations of fraud, paid referrals, or unethical practices by DTLA Law Group are not only unsubstantiated, but false,” the firm said in a statement. “We

[See DTLA, A6]

Trump’s first year sparks a legal war

Federal executive and judicial branches fight over the future of the rule of law in the U.S.

By KEVIN RECTOR

A few months into President Trump’s second term, federal appeals court Judge J. Harvie Wilkinson III — a conservative appointee of President Reagan — issued a scathing opinion denouncing what he found to be the Trump administration’s unlawful removal of Kilmar Abrego Garcia to his native El Salvador, despite a previous court order barring it.

“The government is asserting a right to stash away residents of this country in foreign prisons without the semblance of due process that is the foundation of our constitutional order. Further, it claims in essence that

because it has rid itself of custody that there is nothing that can be done,” Wilkinson wrote. “This should be shocking not only to judges, but to the intuitive sense of liberty that Americans far removed from courthouses still hold dear.”

Two months later, U.S. District Judge William G. Young, also a Reagan appointee, ripped into the Trump administration from the bench for its unprecedented decision to terminate hundreds of National Institutes of Health grants based on their perceived nexus to diversity, equity and inclusion initiatives.

Young ruled the cuts were “arbitrary and capricious” and therefore illegal. But he also said there was a “darker aspect” to the case that he had an “unflinching obligation” to call out — that the administration’s actions amounted to “racial dis-

[See Rule of law, A9]

Joy, then dread for Venezuelans in U.S.

Trump administration urges deportations as its travel warning underscores peril.

By ANDREA CASTILLO

WASHINGTON — After President Trump ordered strikes that led to the capture of Venezuela’s president, Nicolás Maduro, celebrations erupted in Venezuelan communities across the United States.

But for many of the hundreds of thousands of Venezuelan immigrants facing possible deportation, their relief and joy was cut by the fear about what comes next from an administration that has zeroed in on Venezuelans as a target.

“Many of us asked ourselves, ‘What’s going to happen with us now?’” said A.G., a 39-year-old in Tennessee who asked to be identified by her initials because she lacks legal status. Even so, Maduro’s ouster gave her a lot of hope for her mother country.

Venezuelans began fleeing in droves in 2014 as economic collapse led to widespread food and medicine shortages, as well as political repression. Nearly 8 million Venezuelans are now living outside the country — including 1.2 million in the U.S.

A.G. and her now-18-year-old son arrived at the southern border in 2019. Since then, she said, they have built a good life — they own a transport company with delivery trucks, pay taxes and follow the law.

Maduro’s fall left her with mixed feelings.

“He’s obviously a dictator, many people have died because of him and he refused to give up power, but the reason that they entered Venezuela, for me what President Trump did was illegal,” she said. “Innocent people died because of the bombs. I’m asking God that it all be for good reason.”

Dozens of Venezuelans and others were killed in the U.S. invasion — more than 100, a government official said — including civilians.

The Trump administra-

[See Immigrants, A7]

Grateful Dead co-founder dies

Guitarist Bob Weir, who wrote “Sugar Magnolia” and sang “Truckin’,” was 78. CALIFORNIA, B1

Rams survive to advance

After trailing late, L.A. rallies to defeat the Panthers 34-31 in the NFC wild-card matchup. SPORTS, D1

A rising force in Mexican music

Singer JOP and his band Fuerza Regida want música mexicana to soar even higher. ENTERTAINMENT, E7

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 75/51. B7

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